TALK TWO

2 Two Plans

"Father, thy will be done, and the glory be thine forever."

MOSES 4:2

When Lucifer fell, the heavens wept over him. The Prophet Joseph Smith and Sidney Rigdon saw his fall in vision and recorded it in section 76. They saw "an angel of God who was in authority in the presence of God," who "rebelled against the Only Begotten Son whom the Father loved." He "was called Perdition, for the heavens wept over him—he was Lucifer, a son of the morning." Lucifer had belonged there. His fall was something heaven mourned.

Abraham's account takes us back to the council before the earth was made. The Lord asked, "Whom shall I send?" One answered "like unto the Son of Man: Here am I, send me." Another also answered, "Here am I, send me." The Lord said, "I will send the first." The second was angry and kept not his first estate, "and, at that day, many followed after him."

To understand what happened, we need to remember what the Father wanted for His children. We were spirits. Our Father had a glorified body and a fullness we had not yet received. We needed bodies of our own and the experience of learning to live faithfully in them. Abraham recorded that the purpose of the earth was to provide a place where we could be proved to see if we would choose the right. We were coming here to grow into something we could not become without a mortal experience.

Michael, the Father, would come to earth as Adam and begin the human family. Lehi says, "Adam fell that men might be; and men are, that they might have joy." Mortality offered God's spirit children bodies and the opportunity for joy, but it also meant we would physically die. The bodies we came to receive would eventually lie in graves, and we could not raise them ourselves. We would also sin, damaging our standing before God and our relationships with one another. Being sorry for wrongdoing would

matter, but sorrow alone could not undo the problem. We needed both resurrection and a way to repent, change, and be forgiven.

This is why the plan required a Redeemer. The prophet Jacob teaches that without an infinite Atonement, our bodies would "rise no more." Alma explains that mercy could not simply set justice aside. An Atonement was required so that God could be "a perfect, just God, and a merciful God also." The Fall opened the way into mortal life, but mortality alone could not bring us to the Father's fullness. Someone had to do the work of overcoming death and redeeming us from sin. That was what stood behind the Father's question, "Whom shall I send?"

Lucifer and Christ both stepped forward, but they were offering different things. The Lord told Moses what each said. Lucifer offered, "I will be thy son, and I will redeem all mankind, that one soul shall not be lost, and surely I will do it; wherefore give me thine honor." The Beloved Son answered, "Father, thy will be done, and the glory be thine forever."

John Taylor explains that the Father had already made His plan known to us. President Taylor writes that "all that His well beloved Son wanted to do was to carry out the will of His Father," while Lucifer came "with a plan of his own." Christ understood what the Father was asking, and He was agreeing to it.

Lucifer promised that everyone would be redeemed. No one would be lost, and he insisted, "Surely I will do it." But the Lord tells us that Lucifer "sought to destroy the agency of man." John Taylor explains that a person deprived of agency cannot choose to do wrong, but neither can that person freely choose the obedience that grows us toward exaltation. President Taylor calls that person with no agency "a serf," someone under another's control. Lucifer's promise of losing no one would have taken away the freedom we needed to grow.

What did he want in return? He said, "Give me thine honor." In section 29, the Lord identifies that honor as "my power." Moses also records that Lucifer wanted God to give him sovereign power. Lucifer was demanding the Father's honor and authority as a condition of carrying out his proposal. The Father's power would be used to impose a plan that defeated the Father's

purpose. Christ's answer was different: "Thy will be done." The Son accepted the work and left the glory where it belongs. Our group noticed an irony in this. Lucifer demanded the Father's honor as the price of his offer. Jesus gave Himself freely and received the Father's fullness. Christ offers to share that inheritance with us.

I have wondered why so many followed Lucifer. After 9/11, Brother Cawley said that the idea of security persuaded Americans to give up more of their freedoms. He was talking about the new searches at airports. I think there is something similar in the appeal Lucifer made. We had not yet experienced mortality, and coming here meant facing the possibility of failing to return to our Heavenly Parents. If we were afraid of that, how would a promise that no one could fail have sounded? Lucifer was offering the appearance of security. I can understand how someone could hear "not one soul shall be lost" and fail to consider what *would* be lost along the way.

The Father wanted His children to become capable of living the life He lives. He told Moses, "This is my work and my glory—to bring to pass the immortality and eternal life of man." Lehi taught that without opposition in all things, "righteousness could not be brought to pass, neither wickedness, neither holiness nor misery, neither good nor bad." We could not become holy without choosing good when another choice was possible. Lucifer's proposal undermined the reason our Father wanted to create an earth for us.

Yet Lucifer's rebellion was itself a choice. Section 29 says a third part of the hosts of heaven turned away "because of their agency." They used their freedom to oppose the plan that gave it to them. The Lord cast Lucifer down, "and he became Satan, yea, even the devil, the father of all lies." The heavens wept. These were members of our family. I think we were sorry to see them go.

Christ was chosen by the Father and accepted the responsibility of carrying out the Father's purpose. John Taylor explains the Son's offer like this: "I will carry out thy plans and thy designs, and, as man will fall, I will offer myself as an atonement according to thy will, O God." President Taylor then writes that "a covenant was entered into between Him and His Father, in which He agreed to atone for the sins of the world." In this way, Christ "became the Lamb slain from before the foundation of the world."

That covenant helps me understand the love between Christ and the Father. Michael wanted His children to receive bodies and eventually share His fullness. But offering us that opportunity required a way through death, and Jesus agreed to provide it. The Father entrusted the future of His family to His Firstborn Son. Jesus would later say to the Father, "Thou lovedst me before the foundation of the world."

Christ would have to live without sin and then willingly offer His life. Speaking of His life, Jesus later explained, "I have power to lay it down, and I have power to take it again. This commandment have I received of my Father." His victory would reach beyond Himself to the whole human family. The Apostle Paul writes, "As in Adam all die, even so in Christ shall all be made alive." Through Christ, we would rise from the grave. Through His Atonement, we could also repent and receive forgiveness. Our choices would still matter, but our failures would not have to be the end of hope. We could change and return to the Father.

We were in that meeting too. We were promised that if we kept our first estate--if we would accept the plan of salvation in the pre-existence--we would be added upon. Being born on this earth means we kept ours. Being born here in the Work means we fought valiantly to support the gospel plan. We chose to come into a life where our choices would matter. Those choices are in front of us now.

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The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.